"My journey is like a river, it's just been flowing in every direction and taken its own path. **I never thought I have to be a mountain, be on top,** stand rock solid and look at everyone from that vantage point."

For Jyotika it has always been about living life to the fullest. At 28, at the peak of her stardom in Tamil cinema, she married actor Suriya and settled down to start a family. Immersed in the new role as a mother of two kids, the actress was content and comfortable. "I wanted to be with them for the initial years because no matter what they say a mom is required to give her absolute time to the kids," she says. Little did she know that this new persona would give a fresh impetus to her passion—acting.

Before it had even dawned on her that she had spent eight years away from the camera, she got an opportunity to stage a comeback. In the Tamil film, *36 Vayadhinile* (At the age of 36), she found herself playing the many women she connected with as a mother and whose unassuming inner brilliance she admired. Jyotika's return from her self-imposed hiatus was on her own terms and conditions, offering her the luxury to strike a perfect work-life balance. It has seen her say umpteen 'Nos' and break norms and perceptions around the shelf life of an actress by starting afresh in her mid-30s to blossoming in her 40s.

"My journey is like a river, it's just been flowing in every direction and taken its own path," she says. The flow has taken her from her well-established base in Chennai back to her hometown Mumbai to be close to her parents and for her daughter's education. This meant saying goodbye to a career in the South, her "foundation" in cinema and where she thrived doing definitive roles in films such as *Mozhi, Kushi, Chandramukhi and Perazhagan.*

It's not taken her long to have a professional rebirth which entailed changing film industries, work culture and even acting in a different language. "I am loving coming back to my roots, speaking my own language [Hindi]. I can improvise; it's giving me a lot of freedom as an actor," she says. Her priorities have changed in the process too. "I do want to play that which I haven't done before. I just do not want to stand next to a male star or be in a big project where I am just a part of it," she says.

Keen to play a grey character, she finally got to do so with the Netflix series *Dabba Cartel*, also her long-format debut. Playing Varuna, a debt-ridden, upper-class woman who wears her privilege on her sleeves, she is cold and not instantly likeable. "She's multilayered, a complex character which many women are because of what they face in society at different stages of their lives," she adds. With its female-led cast, the show exudes feminine energy, showcasing women from different socio-economic-cultural backdrops navigating life and bad decisions.

For Jyotika, feminine energy signifies the generosity of women. 'I don't think it's a sacrifice but a virtue," she says. "There's power in its silence. Women are composed from within, out there multitasking, where resilience is a way of being." Some of her philosophy has reflected in the films she and her husband, actor Suriya, have backed under their banner 2D Films. From *Gargi* starring Sai Pallavi to *Jai Bhim* with Lijomol Jose and *Soorarai Pottru* featuring Aparna Balamurali, all featured strong female characters that have ultimately won the actresses both acclaim and awards.

Enjoying this phase where she is empowering and enacting, Jyotika observes how these days, most of her co-actors tend to be women. Her next is with Sonakshi Sinha and helmed by Ashwiny Iyer Tiwari (*Nil Battey Sannata, Bareilly Ki Barfi*). "This chemistry between man and woman is so typecast that I am enjoying sharing chemistry with a female lead," she says. "It's brought a completely new shade to my career and me as an actor." The new Jyotika is only just getting started.

—Suhani Singh

Location Courtesy: **The Lalit Mumbai** Hair: **Prachina Sulakhe** Makeup: **Devika Rathore**
Stylist: **Radhika Mehra** Asst stylist: **Keyuri Sangoi** Jewellery: **Reborn: Solitaires by Zoya**